

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mrs Abira Rashid

Address: 9 Bicknoller Close Sutton SM2 5NQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to express my strong support for the above planning application. As a woman who lives and works locally in the SM2/Sutton area, and as a mother of my children attending local schools, I write from a perspective that is both professional and deeply personal. I am a resident of SM2 5NQ, and this proposed facility, if approved, will directly serve my family and our wider community.

From reading the Transport Statement and Travel Plan, I am reassured that traffic and parking have been carefully considered. The proposal provides 14 onsite car spaces (including disabled and EV bays) and secure cycle parking, and commits to marshalled onsite parking management and promotion of walking, carsharing and public transport. Surveys show that most existing BASMA users already walk, with over half of Friday attendees arriving on foot and only a minority driving. Parking beat surveys in nearby streets recorded daytime utilisation at under 50%, even on Fridays, indicating spare capacity and that overspill parking is unlikely to be severe.

As a parent, schoolrun safety is paramount to me. I welcome the clear commitment to stagger Friday prayer times so they do not clash with Avenue dropoff and pickup, and to use stewards to supervise vehicle movements during the busiest periods, so Dorset Road will not be affected. The hailandride S2 and S4 bus services and the short walk from Belmont Station also mean many visitors can come without a car, consistent with Sutton Local Plan Policies 35-37 on sustainable travel and appropriate parking.

The proposal reuses an existing brownfield public service site with a modest extension, improved landscaping, cycle parking and onsite car parking. Technical reports show that most existing users

already walk, that parking stress on surrounding streets is well below capacity, and that staggered Friday prayer times and marshalled onsite parking will avoid conflict with school dropoff and pickup. Noise assessment work demonstrates that activities inside a wellinsulated, singlestorey building will remain below existing background levels and will be quieter than the former 24hour ambulance use.

Women's Support and Wellbeing Initiatives:

As a working mother managing the demands of employment, childcare, and family life, I know from personal experience how difficult it is to find time and accessible spaces for personal wellbeing. The proposed BASMA facility has explicitly committed to delivering women-focused support programmes and wellbeing initiatives. These are not peripheral add-ons, they are a vital community service. Many women in our area, particularly those from South Asian and Muslim backgrounds, face social isolation, language barriers, and lack of culturally appropriate support services. A community centre of this kind, managed by a well-respected charity with a proven track record in Sutton, provides the trusted, accessible, local resource that fills a genuine gap.

Safe Spaces for Children and Structured Activities:

As a parent of children at Avenue Primary and Harris Academy, I am keenly aware that after-school provision in the SM2 area is stretched and in high demand. The proposed community centre would provide supervised, structured after-school activities for children in a safe and stimulating environment. Youth clubs, homework clubs, sports sessions, arts activities, all of these can be housed within a facility like this. This is particularly important for children growing up in a diverse area: structured activities in inclusive, welcoming spaces build social skills, resilience, and community bonds that last a lifetime.

Education Beyond the Classroom:

I work in a professional capacity and understand the value of lifelong learning. The F1 use class proposed for this facility encompasses educational programmes that go well beyond religious instruction. Adult education, English language classes, digital literacy workshops, and vocational guidance can all be delivered from this site. For women who may have paused careers, for new arrivals to the borough, and for young people bridging school and employment, these programmes are transformative. I strongly welcome the educational dimension of this proposal.

Elderly Engagement and Combating Loneliness:

My own experience of caring for older relatives has made me acutely aware of the loneliness epidemic among elderly residents. Our area has a significant elderly population, many of whom live alone and lack regular social contact. Community facilities that offer regular, welcoming, accessible social programmes, coffee mornings, health talks, gentle exercise classes, social clubs,

are invaluable in addressing loneliness and social isolation. The proposed BASMA facility is perfectly positioned to serve this role in the SM2 and Belmont community.

Inter-Community Interaction:

I want to speak directly to concerns about whether this facility serves all communities. BASMA has operated Friday prayers at St John's Community Hall on Northdown Road for several years, with no disruption to neighbours, no community tension, and no adverse impact on the local area. A permanent, purpose-fit facility at Dorset Road will allow BASMA to build on this track record and to open its doors more widely, hosting community events, inter-faith activities, and public programmes that benefit all residents regardless of background. Diversity of community provision strengthens a borough; it does not weaken it.

3 halls are proposed - 1 for ladies, 1 for prayers and 1 for multi-use which is for all communities
There will be a publicly available defibrillator which is a vital life saving device.

Support for People Who May Be Lonely or Isolated:

The postcode SM2 5NQ, like much of the Belmont area, contains a significant proportion of residents who are at risk of social isolation: elderly people, new mothers, recently arrived families, people with disabilities, and those dealing with mental health challenges. Community facilities like the proposed BASMA centre are among the most powerful tools available to local communities to address these issues outside of statutory services. I urge the Planning Authority to recognise the substantial public benefit this facility will deliver.

I offer my wholehearted support for this application and respectfully request that the Planning Authority grant planning permission.

Yours faithfully,

Abira Rashid